

| THE BEST AND THE WORST                                                            |                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                  | HOW THE WORLD'S TOP TEAMS HAVE PERFORMED IN |  |  |  |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|--|--|--|
|  |                                  |                               |                               |                                             |  |  |  |
| AUSTRALIA                                                                         | PAKISTAN                                                                                                          | SRI LANKA                                                                                                      | NEW ZEALAND                                                                                                      |                                             |  |  |  |
| <b>VICTORIES</b>                                                                  |                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                  |                                             |  |  |  |
| Won the ICC World Cup, 2007; Champions Trophy, 2009                               | Won the World Twenty20, 2009                                                                                      | —                                                                                                              | —                                                                                                                |                                             |  |  |  |
| <b>KNOCK-OUT ROUND FINISHES</b>                                                   |                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                  |                                             |  |  |  |
| Semi-finalists in the ICC World Twenty20, 2010                                    | Finalists in the World Twenty20, 2007; semi-finalists in the World Twenty20, 2010; and the Champions Trophy, 2009 | Finalists in the ICC World Cup, 2007; the World Twenty20, 2009; and semi-finalists in the World Twenty20, 2010 | Finalists in the Champions Trophy, 2009; semi-finalists in the ICC World Cup, 2007; and the World Twenty20, 2007 |                                             |  |  |  |
| <b>LEAGUE PERFORMANCES</b>                                                        |                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                  |                                             |  |  |  |
| Knocked out from the Super 8s league in the World Twenty20, 2009                  | Failed to make Super 8s in the ICC World Cup, 2007                                                                | Knocked out from Super 8s league in the World Twenty20, 2007 and Champions Trophy, 2009                        | Knocked out from the Super 8s league in the World Twenty20 in 2009 and 2010                                      |                                             |  |  |  |

*The results of the 2010 ICC World Twenty20 are updated till the end of the Super 8s league*

two of the five titles. The Pakistanis, called 'mentally retarded' by their former coach, recovered from a nightmare 2007 World Cup, won an ICC title and made three semis. Sri Lanka, part of the Asian batting-friendly and spin-reliant brand of cricket, have made two finals and a semi-final.

Then there is India, who after their dizzy World Twenty20 win in 2007, have gone in the opposite direction. The last two World T20s have been separated by 10 months and the Tropic of Cancer. In those events India have lost twice to the West Indies and once each to Australia, Sri Lanka, England and South Africa. In the Champions Trophy, to Pakistan and Australia.

Former India bowling coach Venkatesh Prasad says, "The batsmen struggled to negotiate the bouncer and our bowlers themselves did not use it smartly and effectively." A Twitter-sized summary of India came from former Australian skipper Ian Chappell who wrote, "They made selection blunders, tactically were questionable, in the actual skills of the game were lacking at crucial times."

Two of those three problems land at the captain's feet: M.S. Dhoni has

gone from being one of Youngistan's shiny, happy people to a 28-year-old whose grey hair has doubled in a year. A man of smarts, self-confidence and a seventh sense, he is today a leader in perpetual unrest. The team's results oscillate between extremes and the media swings between worshipful and deprecating. What should really worry Dhoni is the nature of his decision-making. Insiders believe he must also find out whether he still retains a hold on the team. What used to be the man's strengths—calmness, a relaxed leadership which licenced every man to be himself—have now turned into his weaknesses after three years in the job. During crises, the whip-crackers aren't meant to relax. Optional practice works but not all the time, not in all situations.

Most certainly not with young batsmen exposed against the short ball on the hard, bouncy Barbados wicket. An Indian cricketer says what Dhoni's frontline World T20 batsmen needed to ask themselves was, "Did I practice in these 10 months? What did I do to get better than what I was like in England?" Former India

## Where Are They Now?

Once India's quickest bowlers, they are now slower and absent



### ISHANT SHARMA

The beanpole who tormented Ricky Ponting in his debut series is now bowling at a pace that makes him a medium pacer.



### S. SREESANTH

Possibly the quick bowler most suited to the T20 format; he has mended his ways but is not treated as an asset.



### MUNAF PATEL

Once called the Ikhar Express. Patel has dropped pace and routinely shelved from the shortest form of the game.